

Literature Review

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Literature Review

The purpose of this literature review is to analyze how Latin mental health and counseling practices can be better understood through frameworks of historical trauma, different ways people explain mental health, and decolonial approaches to healing. Three articles were reviewed the first one being “*Chicana and Chicano Mental Health: Alma, Mente y Corazón*” (Flores, 2013), the second one is “*A Borderlands View on Latinos, Latin Americans, and Decolonization*” (Hernández-Wolfe, 2015), and lastly, “*Decolonizing “Multicultural” Counseling Through Social Justice*” (Goodman & Gorski, 2016). After reading the articles, the literature review was separated into three themes, Historical trauma, Cultural understandings of Mental Health, and Decolonial Counseling Approaches. These themes form the structure of the review that follows.

The first theme addresses that Latin mental health intertwines with the history of colonization and oppression. Flores (2013) explains how trauma is still impacting Chicano and acknowledges that colonization is the cause of challenges within the Latin community stating that “intergenerational trauma and the prevalence of racism, discrimination, and institutionalized systems of oppression...adversely affect the spiritual, emotional, and physical well-being of Latinos and Chicanos” (Flores, 2013, p. 3). This trauma is not only historical but ongoing, because it continues to be a challenge for many people. Some examples include microaggressions when migrating to the US, discrimination, an unstable economy along with laws that target minorities. Flores addresses microaggressions and describes them as “brief and commonplace daily verbal, behavioral, and environmental indignities...that communicate hostile, derogatory, or negative racial, gender, sexual-orientation, and religious slights” (Flores, 2013, p. 4). Having these experiences can damage an individual's mental health conditions and

contribute to the lack of seeking help because many counselors have invalidated Latin worldviews throughout history.

Hernandez-Wolfe addresses living in the in-between spaces where individual identities collide. The word Hernandez-Wolfe uses is called “Nepantla”, and it is a Nahuatl word that means “in-betweenness” which opens the discussion of experiences between two worlds, cultures, languages and/or identities. Addressing the in-between spaces of culture opens how we view “trauma, resistance, and solidarity” and focuses on how we can overcome those challenges (2015, p. 118). This lens challenges counseling because it acknowledges trauma through history and community rather than dismissing them. Goodman and Gorski (2016) address that trauma is connected to problems such as violence, poverty, and inequality. They explain that when counselors only focus on the medical side, it misses how racism and classism affect people's lives (p. 167). As a result of this, it is argued that “traditional” counseling can unintentionally damage the clients counseling journey.

The second theme is the importance of understanding Latin culture in the way in which they express themselves, show emotions, and explain mental health. Flores writes that western models often invalidate meaningful experiences. She states that there are three Chicano expressive categories called “nervios, locura, and problemas de la vida”, and acknowledges how understanding this framework can help counselors help Latino culture interpret their emotions. An example in the community is that at times individuals feel overwhelmed with what they are experiencing but instead of saying “overwhelmed” or “stress” they describe it as “nervios” that affect the body and the mind (Flores, 2013, p. 4). Counselors understanding their client's language and culture will help understand their worldview. A vignette highlighted the story of Julia, a Latina that was experiencing panic because of her husband immigration case. Julia

addresses distress as nervous, but it is acknowledged that this can reduce stigma and make sense of the symptoms she is experiencing due to the sociopolitical stress she is going through. (Flores, 2013, p. 62). Hernandez-Wolfe argued that testimonies and storytelling could also work as a form of healing for the community, because it offered “a collective voice, with the purpose of raising consciousness and social and political change” (2015, p.101). However, Goodman and Gorski (2016) argued that western counseling has dismissed cultural models and adapted to Eurocentric models that dismissed various cultures and invalidated multiculturalism (p. 6).

The third theme acknowledges that decolonial approaches in counseling are needed to challenge oppression. Goodman and Gorski (2016), address that multicultural counseling can still damage clients by applying the western models to all clients without realizing. According to the textbook, it is important for counselors to understand oppression and be a part of advocacy for the community to avoid western models to dismiss clients' culture and experiences (p. 45). Hernandez-Wolfe (2015), notes that decolonial healing is a way to build community and connection addressing trauma. Flores (2013) addresses that counselors should focus on the Latin communities' strengths because many Latin clients avoid services due to the counselor's lack of cultural understanding.

In conclusion, the three articles address that Latin mental health must be acknowledged through the lens of understanding historical trauma, clients' culture, and use decolonial healing practices. It is argued that colonization continues to influence the way counselors treat clients and how their mental health is affected. To be an effective counselor, they must practice cultural grounding, decolonization of Western/Eurocentric ideologies, and be an advocate. Overall, it is noted that decolonization healing practices is not just about understanding clients' culture but also addressing their social and political challenges that shape their Latin experiences.

References

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